The Extra Room

Xiara Acosta

The first room appeared the morning after Delia told her husband she was fine.

It was small, more of a closet, wedged between the bathroom and the linen cabinet where there had always been a wall. It had a window that looked out on nothing in particular and a floor of plain pine boards. Delia stood in the doorway in her robe and said, out loud, “Huh.”

Marcus didn’t see it. He walked right past on his way to the shower, and when she pointed, he looked at the linen cabinet and asked if they were out of towels.

“No,” she said. “We’re fine.”

By that night there were two rooms.

She learned the rules the way you learn any house, by bumping into them in the dark. It wasn’t every lie. Telling the cashier she didn’t need a bag when she did, nothing. Telling her mother the lasagna was good, nothing. But when she told her sister she wasn’t hurt about the wedding seating, a room opened at the end of the upstairs hall with a slanted ceiling and a radiator that ticked. When she told her boss she didn’t mind covering the weekend, a sunroom unfolded off the kitchen like a fan.

The rooms only came for one kind of lie. The ones about her.

They were never ugly. That was the strange part. Each one was clean and empty and lit with a pale, patient light, the light of a Sunday afternoon before anybody needs you. She started going into them when the house got loud. She’d sit on the floor of the room and listen to the radiator and feel, for a few minutes, nothing at all. It was the best feeling she knew.

By the end of the first year there were eleven rooms. The house had become difficult to describe. Guests got lost on the way to the bathroom and came back looking puzzled. The cat moved into the sunroom and refused to leave. Marcus, who still couldn’t see any of it, said the place felt drafty and turned up the heat.

“Are you happy?” he asked her one night. He asked it carefully, the way you test ice.

“Of course,” she said, and somewhere above them she heard the soft sigh of a door opening onto a staircase that had not been there before.

She found the staircase the next morning. It went up past the attic, past the roof, into a long corridor of identical white doors. She walked it for an hour. Every room was empty. Every room was hers. Each one had been built from a sentence she’d said to keep the peace, and standing in the middle of it, she understood that she had built a whole second house that no one else could enter. She had never been so alone in her life.

She went downstairs and found Marcus making eggs.

“I’m not fine,” she said.

He turned around with the spatula in his hand. She waited for the house to do something, to groan or collapse or swallow her whole, but it just stood around her, ordinary and listening.

“I haven’t been for a long time,” she said. “I don’t like the weekends at your parents’. I hated that you skipped my sister’s wedding. I don’t know if I want to stay at my job. I don’t know what I want, actually. I’ve just been saying yes so nobody has to look at me too hard.”

Marcus put down the spatula. The eggs started to burn and neither of them moved.

“Okay,” he said slowly. “Okay. Can I ask you something?”

She nodded.

“Is that why the house feels so big?”

She stared at him.

“I can’t see anything,” he said. “I want to be clear. I’m not crazy. But sometimes I’m walking down the hall and it goes on longer than it should. Like there’s a whole floor up there nobody’s using.” He rubbed his face. “I thought it was me. I thought I was the one keeping something from you.”

That night she took him upstairs. He couldn’t see the staircase, so she held his hand and told him where to step, and he trusted her, which felt like its own kind of door. They walked the white corridor together. She told him what each room was for. The wedding.

The weekend shift. The day his mother said she'd let herself go and Delia laughed it off. The night he asked if she was happy.

At every door, after she told the truth, the room got a little smaller. Not gone. Just smaller, like something exhaling.

It took months. Some rooms took one conversation. Some took ten. Some she still hasn't managed to close, because there are things you don't know how to say yet, even to someone holding your hand on a staircase. The house is still bigger than it should be. Guests still get lost sometimes.

But the cat has moved back into the kitchen. And when Delia needs somewhere quiet now, she doesn't climb up past the roof. She sits on the back steps, where Marcus can find her, and when he asks how she is, she takes a breath and checks, honestly, before she answers.